

Most Likely Professional Starters in the 2027 Draft Class

Evaluating future professional starters is often very different from evaluating future draft picks.

The loudest stuff does not always produce the longest careers. Every year, pitchers with premium velocity and elite breaking balls move to the bullpen, while others with less eye-catching arsenals spend a decade turning over major league lineups. The challenge is identifying which traits are most likely to survive the transition from amateur baseball to the professional game.

For this exercise, the focus is not on draft position, pure upside, or the quality of an individual pitch. Instead, the emphasis is on the characteristics that keep pitchers in rotations: workload, command, arsenal depth, durability, athleticism, and the ability to consistently attack hitters from both sides of the plate. While no projection is ever certain, some profiles provide a clearer pathway to long-term starting success than others.

Many of the names on this list have already handled significant collegiate workloads. Others pair unusual pitch mixes with advanced strike-throwing ability. A few possess the type of complete repertoires that allow them to attack hitters in multiple ways without relying on a single carrying pitch. What unites them is not necessarily having the best stuff in the class, but having the strongest foundation to remain starters as the level of competition continues to increase.

The difference between a future starter and a future reliever is often much smaller than it appears. Sometimes it is a fourth pitch. Sometimes it is command traits. Sometimes it is simply durability. As a result, this ranking reflects projection as much as performance.

These are the 10 pitchers from the 2027 class I would bet on most heavily to remain professional starters.

Number 10: Easton Hawk, RHP, UCLA

2026 Stats: 1.93 ERA | 42.0 IP | 1.143 WHIP | 52 K | 19 BB | 2.74 K:BB

Hawk earns the final spot on this list because few pitchers in the class possess his combination of athleticism, arm speed and mechanics, and starter upside. While he spent 2026 anchoring the back end of UCLA's bullpen, the underlying traits suggest more than a traditional relief profile. The combination of premium velocity, a legitimate out pitch, and a full arsenal gives him a realistic pathway toward handling a professional starter's workload.

The slider is the centerpiece of the profile and the primary reason he appears here. Thrown in the mid-80s with sharp depth and late finish, the pitch consistently generated swing-and-miss while serving as his preferred weapon against both right-handed and left-handed hitters. The shape already projects as a professional out pitch and provides the foundation of which the rest of the arsenal is built.

The fastballs provide much of the upside. Hawk operates in the mid-to-upper 90s, touches triple digits, and pairs the velocity with multiple movement profiles through a four-seam and sinker combination. The addition of a promising changeup during 2026 further strengthened the starter projection, giving him another avenue for handling opposite-handed hitters. Few pitchers this far down the list can match the raw quality of the arsenal.

The biggest developmental question is whether Hawk can maintain his stuff and strike throwing while facing lineups multiple times. The fastball-slider combination is already good enough to succeed in short bursts, but professional starters must consistently command multiple pitches deep into outings. While the changeup showed encouraging progress during 2026, it still needs further refinement to become a reliable weapon against left-handed hitters. Additionally, Hawk has yet to demonstrate the durability and consistency required of a full-season starter, making the transition from high-leverage reliever to rotation piece the defining test of his development.

Why #10: Hawk ranks here because of the combination of athleticism, velocity, and starter projection. The reliever floor is already quite high, but the long-term value comes from the possibility that the arsenal, command, and workload continue progressing. If that happens, he has as much room to climb as almost anyone in the class.

Number 9: Will Sanford, RHP, Oregon

2026 Stats: 3.74 ERA | 84.1 IP | 1.221 WHIP | 126 K | 46 BB | 2.74 K:BB

Sanford earns a place on this list because he already possesses two of the most important ingredients for professional starting pitching: a proven workload and elite bat-missing ability. Across more than 84 innings during Oregon's Super Regional run, he established himself as one of the premier strikeout artists in the country while building a profile around one of the best fastball-curveball combinations in the class.

The foundation of the profile is the fastball. Featuring exceptional carry and one of the flattest approach angles among pitchers evaluated, the pitch generated whiffs at an elite rate while allowing Sanford to control the upper part of the strike zone. The curveball serves as an ideal complement, providing a dramatically different movement plane and giving him a true put-away weapon capable of ending at-bats against either handedness. Together, the two pitches form one of the strongest primary combinations in the 2027 class.

What makes Sanford particularly interesting in a starter projection context is the room remaining in the supporting arsenal. While the fastball and curveball already carry the profile, both the slider and changeup flashed traits that suggest they can become meaningful contributors. The changeup, in particular, produced exceptional underlying results in limited usage and could eventually provide the answer against left-handed hitters that elevates the overall profile.

The developmental question centers around strike throwing. Sanford walked 46 hitters in 84.1 innings and frequently worked from less-than-ideal counts despite possessing premium stuff. Professional starters can survive occasional command lapses, but consistently pitching from behind eventually becomes problematic. This led to a lot of damage coming with runners on. Improving efficiency and reducing free passes would significantly strengthen an already compelling starter profile.

Why #9: Sanford ranks here because elite fastballs, quality breaking balls, and proven starter workloads are traits worth betting on. The pitchers ranked above him possess either greater command, deeper arsenals, or stronger overall starter certainty, but few arms in the class offer the same combination of swing-and-miss ability and rotational upside.

Number 8: Wylan Moss, RHP, UCLA

2026 Stats: 2.49 ERA | 65.0 IP | 1.046 WHIP | 76 K | 25 BB | 3.17 K:BB

Moss ranks this highly because he already possesses one of the most important traits for a future starter: a reliable way to get opposite-handed hitters out. While many college pitchers rely heavily on a fastball and breaking ball combination, Moss built his success around a changeup that is already capable of carrying a professional profile. Combined with a quality fastball and a successful season in a major role for UCLA, the foundation of a starter is already present.

The changeup is the defining pitch in the arsenal and the primary reason he appears on this list. Featuring substantial velocity separation, heavy arm-side movement, and consistent down-zone execution, the pitch generated poor contact and swing-and-miss throughout 2026. More importantly, it gives Moss a legitimate weapon against both handedness groups and reduces the likelihood of a future bullpen move. Pitchers with a true plus changeup often have a longer runway as starters, and Moss fits that mold.

The fastball strengthens the profile considerably. Thrown from a highly athletic delivery with excellent extension, the pitch features a unique combination of ride and arm-side movement that allows it to play above its velocity. The pairing of the fastball and changeup creates one of the better two-pitch combinations in the class and gives hitters two distinctly different movement profiles to account for.

The developmental question is straightforward: can Moss develop enough behind the fastball and changeup to consistently turn over professional lineups? The slider currently projects more as a complementary offering than a true finishing pitch, while the sweeper remains in the developmental stages. The ingredients of a starter are already present, but establishing a reliable third pitch would significantly strengthen the projection.

Why #8: Moss ranks here because a quality fastball, a plus changeup, and a history of collegiate success are traits worth betting on. The pitchers ranked above him possess either deeper arsenals or stronger starter certainty, but few arms in the class offer a cleaner pathway to remaining in a professional rotation if the secondary development continues.

Number 7: Sam Cozart, RHP, Texas

2026 Stats: 1.72 ERA | 52.1 IP | 0.726 WHIP | 77 K | 13 BB | 5.92 K:BB

Cozart ranks this highly because he possesses one of the most complete starter foundations in the class. The 6-foot-6, 260-pound right-hander pairs a workhorse frame with a deep arsenal, quality strike throwing, and some of the best results in college baseball. While his 2026 role was primarily at the back of the Texas bullpen, virtually every component of the profile points toward a future in a professional rotation.

The fastball is the foundation. Already one of the best heaters in the class, the pitch generated a 38.7% whiff rate and 19.1% swinging-strike rate while allowing just eight hits all season. The combination of ride, extension, and strike throwing gives Cozart a true carrying pitch capable of overwhelming hitters even when they know it is coming. Few pitchers in the country attacked hitters with as much confidence while maintaining this level of performance.

What separates Cozart from many bullpen-to-rotation candidates is the depth of the repertoire. The slider already projects as a professional out pitch, while the sweeper, splitter, and curveball each provide distinct movement profiles and additional avenues for generating outs. Few pitchers on this list possess four credible secondary offerings, and that level of arsenal diversity significantly improves the likelihood of remaining in a rotation long term.

The primary question is workload rather than stuff. Cozart has already proven he can dominate hitters in shorter stints, but the next step is showing that the command, velocity, and pitch quality hold through a full season as a starter. The ingredients are already present. The remaining challenge is proving they can withstand the demands of turning over lineups multiple times every week.

Why #7: Cozart ranks here because the profile already combines elite stuff, exceptional performance, and a starter-caliber repertoire. The pitchers ranked above him have either logged more starter innings or possess greater present certainty in the role, but few arms in the class offer a higher probability of developing into a professional starter if the transition to the rotation is successful.

Number 6: Aidan King, RHP, Florida

2026 Stats: 3.21 ERA | 87.0 IP | 1.034 WHIP | 92 K | 19 BB | 4.84 K:BB

King ranks this highly because he already does many of the things professional starters are asked to do. He carried a significant workload in the SEC, consistently filled the strike zone, and posted strong results without relying on overwhelming velocity or a singular dominant pitch. While several pitchers in the class possess louder raw stuff, few offer a clearer blueprint for remaining in a rotation over the long term.

A major reason for that projection is his ability to attack hitters in multiple ways. The fastball creates an uncomfortable look from a uniquely low release height, allowing it to play above its velocity, while the cutter, slider, and splitter each provide viable solutions against both right-handed and left-handed hitters. The arsenal may lack a true double-plus offering, but it also lacks an obvious weakness. That balance allows King to navigate lineups without needing everything to be perfect on a given day.

Perhaps the most encouraging aspect of the profile is the strike throwing. King walked just 19 hitters in 87 innings while facing one of the toughest schedules in college baseball. That level of command provides a strong foundation for a professional starter and alleviates pressure on the raw stuff. Pitchers with his combination of athleticism, workload, and strike efficiency generally give organizations every opportunity to keep them in a rotation.

The biggest developmental question is whether one of the secondary offerings emerges as a true put-away pitch. The splitter appears most likely to fill that role, but additional separation from the rest of the arsenal would raise both the ceiling and margin for error. Even without that jump, however, the overall profile already resembles that of a durable professional starter.

Why #6: King ranks here because of his workload, command, and well-rounded arsenal. The pitchers above him possess louder carrying tools or greater upside, but few arms in the class offer a stronger combination of starter certainty and long-term rotational value.

Number 5: Ryan McPherson, RHP, Miss. State

2026 Stats: 3.56 ERA | 43.0 IP | 1.163 WHIP | 51 K | 13 BB | 3.92 K:BB

McPherson ranks this highly because few pitchers in the class offer as many viable paths to remaining a starter. While several arms rely heavily on one or two defining pitches, McPherson attacks hitters with a legitimate five-pitch mix that already resembles a professional starter's arsenal. The combination of velocity, athleticism, strike throwing, and repertoire depth gives him one of the strongest rotational foundations in the class.

The greatest strength of the profile is optionality. The fastball and splitter form the backbone of the arsenal, but neither pitch is forced to carry the entire workload. The splitter is already a legitimate weapon against hitters from both sides of the plate, while the fastball provides enough velocity and life to establish counts and generate swing-and-miss. Beyond those two offerings, the cutter, curveball, and slider each provide distinctly different looks that help keep hitters from sitting on a single movement pattern.

That arsenal depth is particularly important when projecting future starters. Professional lineups eventually adjust to one dominant weapon, forcing pitchers to find additional ways to secure outs. McPherson already possesses multiple avenues to attack hitters depending on count, matchup, or game plan. Few pitchers in the class can match the variety of shapes and velocity bands available within the repertoire.

The primary developmental question is whether one of the breaking balls takes another step forward. The splitter already projects as a defining secondary, but further separation from either the curveball or slider would give him an additional true finishing pitch and raise the overall ceiling. Even without that jump, the totality of the arsenal provides a strong margin for error.

Why #5: McPherson ranks here because repertoire depth matters. The pitchers ranked above him possess stronger track records or greater certainty, but few arms in the class combine a five-pitch mix, quality athleticism, and starter traits as effectively. The overall profile offers one of the clearest paths toward a long-term professional rotation role.

Number 4: Dylan Volantis, LHP, Texas

2026 Stats: 2.08 ERA | 95.0 IP | 1.000 WHIP | 135 K | 28 BB | 4.82 K:BB

Volantis ranks this highly because he already possesses many of the characteristics that allow pitchers to remain starters throughout their professional careers. He logged 95 innings for a College World Series team, missed bats at an elite rate, and consistently turned lineups over despite operating without premium velocity. More importantly, he does it in a way that is difficult to replicate. The combination of his unique delivery, release characteristics, and arsenal construction creates one of the most uncomfortable looks in the class.

The profile is built around one of the best curveballs in amateur baseball. The pitch serves as both a strike stealer and a put-away offering, allowing Volantis to win counts early before finishing hitters with the same weapon later in the at-bat. Its shape is amplified by his unusually high release point and the deception created by his delivery, producing a steep downhill look that hitters consistently struggled to recognize and square up. Few pitchers on this list possess a carrying pitch as established as Volantis's curveball. What strengthens the starter projection is that the curveball is not carrying the entire profile on its own. The sinker gives him a reliable foundation and the slider presents hitters with a completely different breaking-ball look. The repertoire allows him to attack hitters in multiple ways while maintaining the same deceptive release characteristics throughout the arsenal.

The primary developmental question centers around the splitter. The curveball, sinker, and slider already provide enough quality to support a professional starting role, but the continued growth of the splitter would give Volantis another reliable answer against opposite-handed hitters and further reduce hitters' ability to sit on his breaking-ball heavy approach. The pitch already flashes intriguing traits, and if it develops into a consistently above-average offering, it would significantly strengthen a profile that already possesses many of the characteristics associated with long-term starters.

Why #4: Volantis ranks this highly because he combines a proven starter's workload with one of the best individual pitches in the class and a delivery that consistently creates uncomfortable at-bats. The pitchers ranked above him offer either greater pure stuff or overall certainty, but few arms in the country possess a stronger long-term case for remaining in a professional rotation.

Number 3: Tomas Valincius, LHP, Miss. State

2026 Stats: 3.50 ERA | 97.2 IP | 1.075 WHIP | 134 K | 20 BB | 6.7 K:BB

Few pitchers in the class were asked to shoulder as much responsibility as Valincius. He worked deep into games, handled nearly 100 innings, and maintained strikeout production without sacrificing efficiency, giving him one of the strongest performance records among 2027 draft prospects. While many pitchers on this list are still projecting toward larger workloads, Valincius has already demonstrated he can carry one for an entire season.

The profile revolves around a power sinker-slider combination that consistently put hitters on the defensive. The sinker generates uncomfortable contact and allows him to attack the strike zone aggressively, while the slider gives him a reliable weapon for finishing at-bats against both right-handed and left-handed hitters. Together, they form one of the most effective pitch pairings in the country and provide the foundation for his success.

What separates Valincius from many hard-throwing college arms is his ability to maintain that effectiveness throughout an outing. The strike throwing is advanced, the workload is proven, and the approach rarely changes regardless of count or situation. Hitters know the sinker and slider are coming, yet few found a consistent answer for either pitch throughout 2026.

The biggest question surrounding the profile is one faced by many sinker-slider starters. Both pitches grade as potential professional weapons, but professional rotations are often built on more than two offerings. The changeup already flashes enough quality to suggest a solution exists, and its continued development could be the difference between a dependable starter and a pitcher capable of consistently handling advanced lineups multiple times through an order. The encouraging part is that this is not a conversation about whether the primary pitches are good enough. They clearly are. It is simply a question of how much more complete the profile can become.

Why #3: Valincius ranks this highly because he pairs one of the strongest workload records in the class with elite strike throwing and a dominant sinker-slider combination. The pitchers ranked above him offer more complete repertoire depth, but few arms enter 2027 with a stronger track record of consistently succeeding in a starter's role.

Number 2: Dax Whitney, RHP, Oregon State

2026 Stats: 2.00 ERA | 63.0 IP | 0.952 WHIP | 104 K | 18 BB | 5.78 K:BB

Whitney sits near the top of this list because few pitchers in the country can match both the quality and depth of his arsenal. The Oregon State right-hander pairs premium velocity with multiple bat-missing secondaries, giving hitters no obvious avenue for attack. If this article were ranking the best right-handed pitchers in the class, Whitney would be number one. The reason he sits here instead is that this ranking prioritizes the likelihood of remaining a long-term professional starter rather than overall talent alone.

The fastball-slider combination forms the core of the profile. The fastball operates in the upper-90s with exceptional carry through the zone, while the slider already profiles as a legitimate professional out pitch. Both offerings generate swing-and-miss at elite rates and can be deployed against hitters from either side of the plate. Unlike many power pitchers, Whitney does not stop there. The curveball and changeup provide additional movement patterns and velocity bands, giving him one of the deepest repertoires in the class and multiple ways to navigate lineups. The overall package is unusually difficult to find. Whitney combines premium stuff with strike throwing, athleticism, and enough arsenal versatility to avoid becoming overly reliant on any single pitch. Few pitchers entering 2027 can match the combination of present performance and future upside he brings to the mound.

The primary question is durability rather than pitch quality. Whitney has already demonstrated enough stuff to start professionally, but maintaining that arsenal over the course of a full professional workload remains the final hurdle. High-end velocity and power breaking balls place significant demands on the arm, and professional organizations will want to see that the stuff, command, and health hold up as innings continue to accumulate. It is a smaller question than most pitchers face, but it is one of the few remaining questions in the profile.

Why #2: Whitney ranks this highly because he offers the best combination of stuff and starter upside in the class. The pitcher ranked above him presents slightly less risk and a longer track record of carrying a starter's workload, but few arms in amateur baseball possess a more complete collection of pitches or a higher ceiling than Dax Whitney.

Number 1: Chris Levonas, RHP, Wake Forest

2026 Stats: 2.82 ERA | 73.1 IP | 1.050 WHIP | 116 K | 33 BB | 3.52 K:BB

Levonas enters 2027 with one of the strongest combinations of performance and repertoire depth in the class. He struck out 116 hitters in 73.1 innings, carried a full-season workload for a national contender, and did so while deploying arguably the deepest arsenal of any pitcher evaluated.

The greatest strength of the profile is not a single offering. It is the ability to attack hitters in different ways without becoming predictable. The fastball gives him a foundation built on premium velocity and quality shape, while the cutter, curveball, slider, and changeup each provide distinct movement profiles and velocity bands. Few pitchers in the class can present hitters with that many legitimate options over the course of a game. The slider serves as the headline pitch and the primary finishing weapon. It generates swing-and-miss against both right-handed and left-handed hitters, functions in virtually any count, and gives Levonas a dependable way to end at-bats when he needs a strikeout. What makes it especially dangerous is that hitters cannot simply gear up for it. The rest of the arsenal is strong enough to steal strikes, manage contact, and force constant adjustments throughout a lineup's second and third look.

Equally important is the adaptability of the profile. When one pitch is not at its best, Levonas has multiple alternatives. When hitters begin adjusting to one movement pattern, he has another available. That flexibility is often what separates pitchers who can survive a professional rotation from those who eventually fall into relief roles. Few pitchers in the class offer that margin for error.

The remaining developmental questions are relatively minor compared to most arms in the class. Continued refinement of the changeup would further strengthen his attack against opposite-handed hitters, and additional physical maturity could unlock another level of velocity maintenance. Neither is required for success, but both represent avenues for future growth.

Why #1: Levonas earns the top spot because no pitcher evaluated combined workload, arsenal depth, adaptability, and present performance more effectively. Other arms offer more raw stuff or greater pure upside, but if the goal is to identify the pitcher most likely to build a long-term professional career as a starter, Chris Levonas is the safest bet in the 2027 class.

Conclusion

Projecting future starters is one of the most difficult exercises in scouting because the answer is rarely determined by raw stuff alone. Velocity can fluctuate, pitch shapes can change, and new offerings can emerge. What tends to endure are the pitchers who consistently find ways to navigate lineups, manage workloads, and maintain effectiveness over the course of a season.

The pitchers on this list arrive at that outcome through very different means. Some, like Chris Levonas and Dax Whitney, pair deep arsenals with premium stuff. Others, such as Tomas Valincius and Dylan Volantis, have already demonstrated the ability to carry major workloads while serving as the backbone of elite rotations. Further down the list are arms built around exceptional individual traits, whether that be Wylan Moss's changeup, Will Sanford's fastball, or Sam Cozart's combination of size and pitch diversity.

What stands out most is that there is no single blueprint for remaining a starter. Some pitchers succeed through command. Others through movement diversity. Some rely on deep repertoires while others lean on a dominant pitch pairing supported by durability and strike throwing. The common denominator is the ability to repeatedly record outs without requiring maximum effort every inning.

Of course, these rankings are not predictions of draft position, nor are they guarantees of future roles. Pitchers develop rapidly. New pitches appear, workloads expand, and command can take dramatic steps forward or backward over the course of a year. Several names outside this list could easily force their way into the conversation before the 2027 draft arrives.

For now, however, these are the arms I would bet on most heavily to remain in professional rotations. Some may eventually become frontline starters. Others may settle into middle or back-end roles. A few will inevitably move to the bullpen. But among the pitchers evaluated for this project, these ten offer the strongest combination of workload history, repertoire construction, adaptability, and rotational sustainability.

Ultimately, the best starting pitchers are not always the ones with the loudest tools. They are the ones who continue taking the ball every fifth day. This group gives itself as good a chance as any in the 2027 class to do exactly that.